



Aachen Cathedral

One of Europe's oldest cathedrals, the burial place of Charlemagne, and the coronation church of German kings for 600 years

On Christmas day 800 CE, Charlemagne (Charles the Great), King of the Franks and ruler of much of western and central Europe, was crowned Holy Roman Emperor. At Aachen, Charlemagne built a new church that drew on the architecture of both the Roman and Byzantine empires. Consecrated in 805, the octagonal Palatine Chapel, at the heart of Aachen Cathedral, was modeled on the 6th-century Byzantine-style church of San Vitale (see p.107), although its barrel and groin vaults and Corinthian columns were classically Roman.

Heavenly architecture

The chapel was to be the spiritual heart of Charlemagne's empire, its ornate mosaic, marble, and fresco decoration symbolizing the connection between Heaven and Earth. Charlemagne was buried in the chapel in 814 and canonized in 1165. As numbers of pilgrims increased, the cathedral was gradually extended.

A MILLENNIUM OF GROWTH

Aachen Cathedral grew over several centuries from the Palatine Chapel and 16-sided ambulatory built for Charlemagne, to the last major works, including the addition of the West Tower, in the 19th century. A large fire in 1656 and bomb damage in World War II meant that parts of the cathedral have been reconstructed.

